RESILIENT VILLAGES ZIMBABWE

Child Protection Policy & Safeguarding Framework

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1.0 Core Definitions

1.1 Definition of a Child

For the purposes of this policy and all institutional operations conducted by Resilient Villages Zimbabwe (RVZ), a **Child** is defined as any human being under the age of eighteen (18) years, in full alignment with national laws and international human rights treaties.

1.2 Definition of Child Abuse & Neglect

Child Abuse constitutes all forms of physical, emotional or mental ill-treatment, sexual abuse, neglect or negligent treatment, commercial or other exploitation resulting in actual or potential harm to the child's health, survival, development, or dignity in the context of a relationship of responsibility, trust, or power.

- **Physical Abuse:** Any non-accidental physical injury or harm inflicted on a child, including hitting, shaking, burning, or inappropriate restraint.
- **Sexual Abuse:** The involvement of a child in sexual activity that they do not fully comprehend, for which they are unable to give informed consent, or that violates the laws or social taboos of society.
- **Mental/Emotional Abuse:** Failure to provide a developmentally appropriate and supportive environment, including persistent intimidation, humiliation, verbal harassment, or isolation.
- **Neglect & Negligent Treatment:** Failure to provide for the essential physical, emotional, educational, or medical development of a child where resources are reasonably available.

2.0 Scope & Applicability

This Policy applies universally to all individuals representing, associated with, or operating on behalf of Resilient Villages Zimbabwe. Adherence is mandatory across all programmatic, administrative, and operational environments.

Covered Personnel:

- Full-time, part-time, temporary, and seasonal employees.
- Members of the Board of Trustees and Advisory Committees.
- Domestic and international volunteers, interns, and seconded personnel.
- Independent contractors, consultants, service providers, and vendors.
- Academic researchers, media representatives, and visiting donors.
- Representatives, focal points, and sub-recipients of partner organizations operating under RVZ agreements.

3.0 Institutional Purpose & Guiding Conventions

3.1 Commitment to Vulnerable Groups

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe is dedicated to empowering communities and creating secure environments where children can thrive. RVZ places special emphasis on the protection, holistic care, and development of:

- **Orphans and Vulnerable Children (OVC):** Ensuring access to psychosocial support, basic necessities, and legal protection.
- **Educational Access & Support:** Fostering safe, inclusive learning environments free from violence, exploitation, and discrimination.
- **Youth Programs:** Building leadership, life skills, and sustainable livelihood opportunities while maintaining strict safeguarding standards.

3.2 International & Regional Framework Alignment

This policy derives its authority from, and explicitly aligns with, key statutory frameworks and international instruments:

- **UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC):** Recognizing the right of every child to protection from all forms of physical or mental violence, injury, abuse, neglect, or exploitation (Article 19).

- **African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child (ACRWC):** Upholding the child's inherent right to life, dignity, and protection against all forms of economic, sexual, physical, and emotional abuse.
- **National Legislation of Zimbabwe:** Including the Constitution of Zimbabwe Amendment (No. 20) Act 2013, the Children's Act [Chapter 5:06], and domestic child protection statutes.

4.0 Comprehensive Anti-Abuse Commitments & Recruitment Screening

4.1 Risk Awareness & Protective Action

RVZ maintains a zero-tolerance stance towards child abuse and exploitation. The organization proactively identifies and mitigates risks to ensure that organizational activities, community interventions, and staff conduct do not expose children to harm.

4.2 Mandatory Vetting & Recruitment Protocols

To prevent unsuitable individuals from working with children, RVZ enforces rigorous screening processes for all prospective employees, volunteers, and associates prior to engagement:

- **Background & Police Vetting:** Submission of an official, valid Police Clearance Certificate (including fingerprint verification).
- **Reference Verification:** Mandatory checks with at least two professional references, directly addressing the candidate’s suitability to work with vulnerable populations.
- **Self-Declaration:** Signing a formal declaration confirming no prior history of child abuse, sexual offenses, or violent misconduct.
- **Probationary Assessment:** Performance and conduct monitoring during initial probation periods before full confirmation of appointment.

4.3 Disciplinary & Legal Enforcement

Any breach of this policy will result in immediate internal disciplinary proceedings, up to and including summary dismissal or termination of contract. Where reasonable suspicion of criminal conduct exists, RVZ will immediately notify national law enforcement and relevant statutory agencies.

5.0 Operational Safeguarding Protocols

5.1 Child Abuse Incident Escalation Procedure

5.1.1 Mandatory Reporting Timelines

Any representative of RVZ who witnesses, suspects, or receives an allegation of child abuse must report the incident on the **same working day** (within 24 hours of notification or observation).

5.1.2 Reporting Channels

- **Primary Channel:** Reports must be submitted in writing to the **Executive Director** or the designated **Safeguarding Focal Person**.
- **Escalation Channel:** If the allegation involves the Executive Director or a senior manager, the report must be submitted directly to the **Chairperson of the Board of Trustees**.

5.1.3 Recording & Documentation

- Documentation must be captured accurately using the official RVZ Safeguarding Incident Form.
- Allegations must be recorded from the perspective of the child, using direct quotes where possible, without initial judgment or alteration of details.

5.1.4 Reporter Protection & Malicious Allegations

- **Good-Faith Reporting:** RVZ guarantees complete protection against retaliation, victimization, or employment detriment for any person who reports suspected abuse in good faith, even if an investigation proves the concern unfounded.
- **Malicious Allegations:** Deliberately false or malicious allegations made against an individual will be treated as severe misconduct and subjected to strict disciplinary action.

5.2 Associate Operational Guidelines & Code of Conduct

5.2.1 Operational Standards

All personnel and associates must uphold the following operational rules:

- Maintain an open, transparent, and safe environment when interacting with children.
- Avoid one-on-one, unobserved interactions with children whenever possible.
- Never engage in physical punishment, degrading treatment, or emotionally abusive language.
- Never secure or permit unauthorized photography, filming, or digital publication of children without verified, written parental/guardian consent and institutional approval.

5.2.2 Investigation Procedures

Upon receipt of a formal safeguarding report:

- **Immediate Suspension:** Any employee or associate under investigation for alleged child abuse will be placed on immediate administrative suspension pending the outcome of the enquiry.
- **Independent Investigation:** An internal investigation panel, potentially augmented by external independent advisers, will review the evidence within 14 calendar days.
- **Legal Action:** If an allegation of abuse or a malicious false claim is substantiated, RVZ will initiate formal disciplinary action and refer the case to the national statutory authorities for legal prosecution.

5.3 Confidentiality Standards & Statutory Agency Referral Directory

5.3.1 Data Protection & Confidentiality Rules

- Information regarding suspected or confirmed child abuse cases must be treated as strictly confidential.
- Data sharing is restricted strictly to a **need-to-know basis** among authorized safeguarding personnel, senior leadership, and legal authorities.
- Prior to legal or disciplinary determination, all communications, documents, and records must refer to the matter using the phrase **"alleged abuse"** to preserve legal rights and administrative fairness.

5.3.2 Statutory Agency Referral Directory

Where an incident requires external referral, immediate contact must be established with the appropriate statutory bodies and civil society protection networks listed below:

Agency / Organization	Primary Mandate & Contact Focus
ZRP Victim Friendly Unit (VFU)	Specialized police section for handling child sexual abuse, domestic violence, and physical assault cases.
Department of Social Development / Social Services	Lead statutory body under the Ministry of Public Service for child welfare, state care, and legal protective intervention.
Ministry of Justice, Legal & Parliamentary Affairs	Administration of justice, victim support services, and legal processing of child-related offenses.

Agency / Organization	Primary Mandate & Contact Focus
Childline Zimbabwe	24-hour toll-free helpline, crisis counseling, legal advice, and emergency response services for children.
Musasa Project	Emergency shelter, legal assistance, and psychosocial support for female victims of gender-based violence and abuse.
Zimbabwe Women Lawyers Association (ZWLA)	Provision of legal aid, litigation support, and rights advocacy for women and vulnerable children.
CONNECT (Zimbabwe Institute of Systemic Therapy)	Professional counseling, mental health assessment, and psychosocial trauma interventions for affected children.
Legal Resources Foundation (LRF)	Human rights legal education, community legal aid, and access to justice support.
Family Support Trust (FST)	Comprehensive medical treatment, forensic evaluations, and clinical counseling for child survivors of sexual abuse.
UNICEF Zimbabwe	Technical advisory, emergency international support, and child rights advocacy oversight.
Plan International Zimbabwe	Partner organization specializing in community-based child protection and youth rights programs.

6.0 Formal Approval & Authorization Block

This Child Protection Policy has been reviewed, approved, and formally adopted by the executive leadership and Board of Trustees of Resilient Villages Zimbabwe.

Executive Approval Sign-off

Role & Title	Representative Name	Signature & Authorization	Date
Chairperson, Board of Trustees	Sr Stellar Gaihai Khumalo	Person	Date
Executive Director	Jerald Ndungwani	Person	Date

Appendix A: Employee & Associate Acknowledgement Agreement Form

Binding Safeguarding Commitment

I, the undersigned, confirm that I have received, read, and fully understood the **Resilient Villages Zimbabwe Child Protection Policy**. I agree to abide strictly by all standards, operational codes of conduct, reporting guidelines, and confidentiality rules outlined herein.

I understand that compliance with this policy is a mandatory condition of my employment, contract, volunteer placement, or association with Resilient Villages Zimbabwe. I acknowledge that any breach of this policy may lead to immediate disciplinary proceedings, termination of contract, and potential criminal prosecution by national legal authorities.

Requirement	Details
Full Legal Name	Person
ID / Passport Number	_____
Job Title / Operational Role	_____
Department / Unit	_____
Duty Station / Location	Place
Signature	_____
Date	Date

(This signed agreement must be returned to the RVZ Human Resources / Safeguarding Department and retained in the personnel file.)